

6.4 Mobile Gaming: Business Perspectives

Mobile computer games have their history in Nintendo's portable LCD game series "Games & Watch". These games became very popular in the 1980s. These simple miniature consoles introduced a concept of keeping a small source of digitised entertainment in the pocket—constantly available. There were nearly 70 different kind of LCD games⁴. In this series, Nintendo also introduced its most know game character, Mario, as well as brought licensing into active use with using Disney's characters in their games.

In 1990s, Nintendo's markets became more and more competitive with multiple competing LCD game manufactures and thus it introduced a new kind of game consoles—the Gameboy console with changeable came cartridges. The device became the dominant one in the markets and marks currently nearly a synonym for portable game consoles. Nintendo with its partners has launched hundreds of game titles for the device and its more advanced successors.

Wireless gaming (games on mobile phones) emerged with Nokia's launch of the Snake game in 1997. The simple Snake game became surprisingly popular and Nokia brought additional titles to their devices. Simple mobile phone games, similar to the original Snake, are played on small breaks to provide relaxation and a small escape from routines. These games were originally installed permanently on the phones, but nowadays more and more they can be purchased through the mobile networks.

In the end of the 1990s, Japanese success of I-Mode network based games created a boom for WAP-games—games that mobile phone users would use through their WAP-browsers in the phones. In Europe, Nokia's 7100-series of phones were the first ones capable for this activity. The slow connection speeds made these games a very disappointing experience and thus they never reached the mainstream markets. Yet, some SMS-based games have gained popularity, especially when supported with television broadcasting.